THE OTTOMANS



A constant menace
An Ottoman fleet commanded by Kheir-ed-Din sails past the entrance to the harbor at Genoa. No port in the Christian Mediterranean was safe from his raids. At times the Ottomans were allied with the French, as when Kheir-ed-Din joined forces with François I to sack Nice in 1543.

AT THE BEGINNING of the 14th century the Ottoman Turks were a small band of Muslim warriors in northern Anatolia. In a remarkably short time they made themselves rulers of a great land empire and a major naval power. The capture of Constantinople in 1453 completed their conquest of the Byzantine Empire. This was followed by expansion westward and southward that gave them control of the eastern Mediterranean, coastal areas of North Africa, and the Red Sea. Through most of the 16th century the Christian states of the Mediterranean could do little to counter Ottoman naval operations, which threatened Italy and Provence with invasion and filled the slave markets of the Islamic world with Christians carried off by Muslim privateers. Victory at Lepanto in 1571 gave the Christian powers a breathing space, but the Ottoman navy remained a major force into the 18th century.

c.1478–1546

KHEIR-ED-DIN

OTTOMAN NAVAL COMMANDER AND PRIVATEER

Kheir-ed-Din, known to Europeans as Barbarossa, was born on the island of Lesbos, probably to a family of Albanian origin. He went to sea at an early age and became a corsair, a role in which he was initially overshadowed by his elder brother Oruç Reis. Kheir-ed-Din succeeded Oruç as ruler of Algiers in 1518, swearing allegiance to the Ottoman sultan. Like his brother, he helped large numbers of mudejars, Spanish Muslims, to escape from Andalusia to North Africa. He was also extraordinarily active as a corsair, appearing off the coast of Spain, the Balearic Islands, southern France, and Italy, to launch lightning raids that made him both feared and admired. In 1534 he was appointed Fleet Admiral of the Ottoman navy, winning a great victory over the Christian Holy League at Preveza four years later. He retired to Istanbul in 1545, shortly before his death.



FIGHTING CORSAIRS

The Ottoman navy was a hybrid force that drew strength from its diversity. The empire was run by a well organized bureaucracy and had impressive financial resources. Once these were devoted to constructing, equipping, and manning a navy in the late 15th century, a formidable fleet was the almost inevitable result. But the Ottomans also relied heavily upon the skills and initiative of privateers. The Barbary corsairs of Algiers and other North African ports, officially sanctioned by the Ottoman sultans, not only preyed upon Christian merchant shipping and raided the coasts of Christian states, but also provided a considerable percentage of the galleys found in Ottoman war fleets. The daring and aggression of their commanders was a vital adjunct to the more formal fighting style of the official Ottoman navy. The Ottoman state always tended to regard sea power as a support to land operations, best used for transporting large armies such as the 100,000 soldiers employed in the successful siege of Rhodes in 1523, or the 40,000 used in the failed siege of Malta in 1565.

CHRISTIAN DISUNITY

The Christian states around the Mediterranean struggled to mount a unified response as the Ottomans pressed westward. No country alone was sufficiently strong to stand up to the Turks. Venice suffered first and worst. After they had suffered defeat at the hands of the Ottoman navy at the end of the 15th century, the Venetians found all their possessions and trade in the eastern Mediterranean under threat. The Knights of St. John, who operated as Christian predators upon Muslim shipping, were driven out of their stronghold on Rhodes but survived precariously in a new base at Malta. Emperor Charles V and subsequent Habsburg rulers of Spain fought, with little success, to contest Ottoman control of the Muslim states of North Africa. Even when the Christians achieved sufficient unity to send out a combined fleet, they were defeated at Preveza in 1538 and Djerba in 1560, before a victory for the Holy League in the great galley battle of Lepanto in 1571 sent the whole of Christendom delirious with relief.



Ottoman war galley
This 16th-century depiction of an Ottoman galley bristles with cannons. This was more typical of a Venetian galleass of the period—Ottoman ships were usually more lightly armed.

FIREPOWER REVOLUTION

The rise of Ottoman naval power coincided with the introduction of cannon and handguns into naval warfare. On land the Turks were not at all backward in the deployment of gunpowder weapons, but their Christian opponents were definitely more thoroughgoing in their use at sea. Even the Venetians' low and nimble galleys would have a bow gun firing